Missiology and Missions: the state of the art.

Missiology:

A definition:

Missiology is the discipline, which deals with 'mission' as its subject matter. The word mission was coined by 15th century Catholic Jesuit Monk Ignatius of Loyola, which stated that individual members of the Society of Jesus had to adhere to the calling to be "send" into specific parts of destinations. He also emphasized that 'missions' included both the territory as well as the task to be performed in the places of destination. Jan A.B. Jongeneel complements this idea a bit more when he shows that missiology is an academic discipline that describes the history, theory, and practice of the Christian world mission by reflecting on it philosophically, empirically and theologically. The Christian Mission is concerned with the obedience of Christ's missional command (Matt.28:19-20) purely for the glory of His person and the benefit of humanity (Jongeneel 1998: 27-32).

The goal of Christian Missiology.

"Missiology is the study of the "*mission Dei*." It involves all that God has done, is doing, and intends to do to accomplish His purpose. The specific focus in missions is to cross barriers for the communication of the good news for what God has done to reconcile man back to Himself." The purpose for studying Missiology and Missions is therefore "the process of consilience with the mission Dei (Mission of God) as its purpose" (Elliston 2011:22). There are four key terms when we are going to study missiology that is important:

1. *Mission:* This is a singular objective, the *missio Dei*, expressed on God's behalf revealing His desire to seek and safe the lost. This is God's 'modes operandi' which influences the immediate course of history as well as the His long term activity in the world and in the Church utilizing resources amongst mankind for the course of eternity.

2. *Missions:* This purely involves all that which is carrying out God's mission purposes to a generation locally and globally (Acts 1:8). This involves activities that will establish the global church with adequate structures so it is self-sustained and properly governed to produce vibrant ministries like: evangelism, church planting, bible translation, education, community upliftment and development, leadership development, literacy, business and various other things. Missions focus on the transformation of communities by following the Biblical example of Jesus Christ as He commissioned Disciples and gave a clear mandate.
3. *Missionaries:* These are people commissioned by God, the Local Church or an established community who are sent to a specific area or location globally and locally for the furtherance of the Gospel. Missionaries are called by the Holy Spirit and equipped by the local Church to accomplish a complete mission to an existing community (existing missions) or where there is no Church (frontier missions).
4. *Missiologists:* Missiologists look and practice global missions from a missiological perspective aiming to motivate a practical participation of missiology (Stefen 2003:132-133).

The purpose of missiology

The Bible renders the story of God's heart in motion reaching to a lost world essentially through His Son by the Holy Spirit (Green 2003: 319-320). If the primary function of the Church starts with missions, the educational system at theological institutions must focus on sociology and anthropology in the training of all students. Students must cultivate cross-cultural ministry and every faculty member needs to be a "global citizen." An emphasis on sociology and anthropology in ministerial training will prepare students of theology to communicate with the world and give a clear perspective on spiritual formation. This will assist churches to be globally sensitive and theologically sound in their pursuit to reach the lost. It will also give a clear definition for the Church as to what is meant with their role in global missions (Siewart and Valdex 1999:43). Elliston mentions Van Engen's Chapter "What is Mission Theology" in his book "*Mission on the way: issues in mission theology*" (1996, pp. 11-36) presents missiology as an academic discipline from a mission

theology perspective (Elliston 2011:32-33). In this chapter, he points to five key component parts of missiology, which require multidisciplinary research with a theological core:

- *missio Dei* (the mission of God).
- *missio hominum* (the mission of humans),
- *missio eccesiarum* (the mission of the church),
- *missio politica oecumenica* (missions as it draws from an impacts global human civilization),
- *missio futurum* (missions as it relates to the "predictable issues of God's mission as they work out in human history), and
- *missio adventus* ("the in-breaking [the advent] of God, of Jesus Christ in the Incarnation, of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost, of the Holy Spirit in and through the Church" (Elliston 2011:32-33).

Missiology's role in the seminary curriculum.

The central purpose of the study of missiology in a seminary context is to encourage a "biblically informed and contextually appropriate missional action" (Woodberry 1996:221). David Bosch makes the following suggestions pertaining to the role of the seminary curriculum to facilitate this:

- Missiology as a topic can be joined to existing disciplines of study like practical theology to give it a place so there could be a "self-actualization of the Church towards missionary situations".
- Make the introduction to missiology a theological discipline in its "own right" so it can become a "science of the missionary for the missionary".
- Make missiology an central theological discipline that would be evident in the "entire" field of theology (Bosch 1991:41-43).

Missiology and its object of study.

Verkuyl mentions that the "focus of interest" in studying missiology is not essentially about the content of the message but is rather concerned with the missionary or

salvific action of God and the men and women roles within His work as He mandates it. As Theologian Loraine Boettner describes it: “Salvation is accomplished by the almighty power of the Triune God. The Father chose a people, the Son died for them; the Holy Spirit makes Christ’s death effective by bringing the elect to faith and repentance, thereby causing them to willingly obey the gospel. The entire process (election, redemption, regeneration) is the work of God and is by grace alone. Thus God, not man, determines who will be the recipients of the gift of salvation.” (Wells 2008:21). Verkuyl makes it emphatically clear that the object of missiology is the study of the Triune God’s [Father, Son, and Holy Spirit] action of salvation evident in the world that He accomplishes through His people. In this perspective we can recognizes the global Church’s divine mandate where the greatest manifestation of their obedience is wilfully expressed in the missional decree given by Jesus in the Gospels (Matt.28:18-19). Christ promises His Disciples and the church the power of the Holy Spirit when they go into the world to preach the good news of salvation (Acts 1:8). The object of Missiology is therefore to investigate scientifically, historically and critically the “presuppositions, motives, structures, methods, patterns of cooperation, and leadership which the churches bring to their mandate in pursuit” of God’s coming and existing (Verkuyl 1978:5). Missiology is therefore the recognition of Gods saving mission through his Kingdom people (Verkuyl 1978:2) or the proclamation of the Gospel by people commissioned by God declaring salvation through Jesus Christ (Kostenberger 1991:347-362). Verkuyl also stresses the importance of the use of the word “missiology” as he wants to encourage uniformity in the use of language and terminology. Roman Catholic missiologists Thomas Ohm confirms this point and encourages that “a uniform terminology is in the best interest of all denominations” (Verkuyl 1978:2).

Missiology as an academic discipline.

The study of missions is to be conclusively concerned with the Biblical data whereby God functions in the central pericope to reconcile mankind back to Himself (Merill 2007: 117-118). When looking for a missiological model we can be assured that any discipline that addresses human behaviour could be utilized to serve any individual with valid information that would point them directly to an increasing body of missiological theory (Elliston 2011:31). When we evaluate missiology scholastically,

we recognize it as an academic discipline that defines, evaluates, interprets and exercise global missional activities. This academic discipline researches positive and negative trends to establish the missional imperative by the planting, developing and multiplying holistic communities of faith (Stefen 2003:137). There is a different intent between social science and theological research as theological research delineates issues of trustworthiness and truth based on a sound hermeneutical and exegetical foundation, which is the foundation of missiological research. It is important for us to note that missiology is an academic discipline in its own right that can amass its validity through an “organized body of knowledge” and organized methods of “accumulating and ordering that knowledge” (Elliston 2011:31). Verkuyl expresses that there was very little, if any, interest to recognize missiology as part of systematic theology and it received very little support as a body of information. He mentions that missiology is a very difficult category because missiology includes quite a wide spectrum of theological disciplines (Verkuyl 1978:9).

The Challenge of Missiology as an academic discipline:

The challenge of missiology as an academic discipline therefore is to ‘round out’ the other branches of theology in the pursuit to communicate the Gospel throughout the world (Verkuyl 1978:10). Another challenge for missiology as an academic discipline is that some faculties of theology in Western Universities have been secularised which means the Christian Faith does not take priority in religious studies and the discipline of the Christian mission seems unimportant (Jongeneel 1998:32). Verkuyl mentions that there needs to be an essential continuity missiology as an academic discipline needs to establish to uphold its validity in these faculties of education. First, it involves theologians recognizing the positive effect that will contribute to the global task of missions and thereby allowing it to become an essential part of the overall curriculum. Secondly, this requires missionary and diaconal agencies to formulate policies that include missiologists in their contribution showing that the Christian mission has an incredible positive and cardinal place even in secular faculties (Verkuyl 1978:19). Jongeneel mentions that this collaborated effort can complement missiology as an academic discipline when he highlights that as an academic discipline it richly describes the history, theory, and practice of the Christian world mission by reflecting on it philosophically, empirically and

theologically. This would add to the positive effects missiology gives even to secular ideas when it focus on the effective and positive influences it has in the sociological fabric of any community. It needs to be done without compromise though and we need to affirm that the academic discipline of the Christian mission is concerned with the obedience of Christ's missional command (Matt.28:19-20) purely for the glory of His person and the benefit of humanity (Jongeneel 1998:27). Because missiology encompasses and include such a variety fields of study, it requires multidisciplinary methods to understand it as a subject matter. These fields of study could be cross-cultural as well as cross religious and find themselves in a foreign context within a different geographical region. It is therefore required that multiple disciplines are used and to understand that one missional context does not necessarily "fit all" (Elliston 2011:31-32). When we therefore speak of missiology being a scientific discipline, we affirm that as an academic discipline we can systematically research, record and apply scientific observable data. The nature of this data recorded could relate to: biblical authority, history, anthropology, sociology, and how these topics relate to the base of the Christian mission. Verkuyl affirms that the missiological task in every age investigates scientifically the presuppositions, motives, structures, methods, patterns of cooperation, and leadership in which these churches clarify and exercise their missional calling (Verkuyl 1978:6). Researching these areas contributes towards the process by which the Christian message is clearly communicated within its given context. It should aid in the planting of Churches and give a clear directive as to the structure and working of new congregations. It should establish fellowships, which will come into maturity that will eventually replicate the very cycle of mission in their own context sending out missionaries to places where they see the need (Tippett 1987:13). In pursuing God's mission, they also have a concrete knowledge of God's activity in human history combating various evils to see God's Kingdom mandate prosper (Verkuyl 1978:6).

Cautions in missiological education.

When studying and applying missiological principles we need to look at the intentions we have for doing so. We cannot study missionary principles purely out of the selfish desire to see our Churches filled with more programs. Paul writes, "Do nothing out of selfish ambition or vain conceit. Rather, in humility value others above

yourselves, not looking to your own interests but each of you to the interests of the others" (Phil. 2:3-4 N.I.V.). Another caution is that we can focus too much one a specific component in missiological studies. We can overemphasize the dynamics of cross-cultural communication or even focus heavily on culture at the expense of vital aspects of one's personal faith (Martinson 1999:43). The challenge is to keep in balance the tensions between the spiritual, academic and the practical aspects of the missional task (Woodberry 1996:271). We should also caution not to neglect a multicultural partnership within the missional context. Missiological education must include multi-cultural and multi-ethnic mission teams to display a unity within diversity to display the unity of Christ's Church. Higher educational institutions of theology must incorporate the local Church to assist in the global mission. Without the local Church, the missiological task can become just a theological idea and not a practical aid. Students of theology should therefore have adequate knowledge of history and its challenges to bridge this gap (Elliston 2011:22).

A brief survey of missiological scholars and their major contributions (works).

Missiology is a relatively new discipline that was recognized by Norwegian author Professor O.G. Myklebust in 1867 in his work "The Study of Missions in theological education." He observed that the place of missions in Protestant theology schools became more apparent in their curriculums that year. The goal of these studies was to "foster missionary support among future pastors at the level of the local congregation, while simultaneously providing a modicum of pre-field training for missionary candidates" (Scherer 1985:446). This would assist the Church as a whole to restore a missional primacy to theology, something lacking since the "Constantinization" of the Church (Steffen 2003:138). Another major contributor was Friedrich D. Schleiermacher (Nov.21, 1768 – Feb.12, 1834) who evaluated the position of missions within the broader discipline of theology. Schleiermacher shows the difference between "continuous missions" and "sporadic missions" (Verkuyl 1978:7). He limited his understanding of missions because of his missionary perspective being restricted by both culture and history and he make a claim that missionary priority is not motivated by a call to proclaim salvation to all but rather just a reflection of the individual showing God's laws and customs through their everyday life and convictions (Verkuyl 1978:8). Another two contributors that were quite

influential is Abraham Kuyper (29 Oct.1837 – 8 Nov.1920) and Herman Bavinck (13 Dec.1854 - 29 Jul.1921). Kuyper places missiology among the practical disciplines or as he mentioned the “diaconological group” which he then further divides into didactic, presbyterial, diaconal, and laic (layperson) disciplines calling it “prosthetics”. Kuyper includes missiology under the “didactic disciplines” for which he says aids methods in Christianizing those people not brought to the Lordship of Christ. Bavinck affirms that missiology should be placed amongst the practical disciplines and should be seen as complimentary and independent to other theological disciplines. In doing this, he objects to Kuyper who classed it in the didactic group when Bavinck noted that it should also be classed under teaching as well as service and even fellowship (Verkuyl 1978:8).

A critical response: Verkuyl shows brilliantly that the priority of God should be the ultimate priority of the Church but shows that each generation should recognize the importance of the study of missions to invigorate their missional task. Elliston notes that Christian education cannot become a mere academic discipline that seems oblivious to the ultimate purpose of God to transform and save the world. Verkuyl shows that even though missiology is a neglected discipline in some academic circles, that it demands recognition if the Church wants to grow.

Missions:

The biblical foundation, proposed by Verkuyl.

Verkuyl mentions that essentially the Church of Jesus Christ need to turn back to the Scriptures and recognize the God who speaks to us through the Bible and we need to pay fresh attention to God who is described in the Old Testament as the “sending God.” He encourages us to observe Jesus who is spoken of in Scripture as “the One sent from the Father.” In all he calls the Church back to the biblical priority of a loving and sending God (Verkuyl 1978:89). When writing of the “How” of the foundation of missions he mentions that the priority in past missiology was to “pull a series of proof-texts out of the Old and New Testaments” and then assuring oneself that the missionary task was accomplished. Such shallow observations of the text could be avoided by studying intensely the deeper structure of the complete Biblical message

concerning the missional task. He adds that “the proof-text method” just does not give substance to the missional prerogative and that we need to “consider the very structure of the whole biblical message.” Verkuyl then shows his own brief contribution in understanding of the Biblical foundation for missions (Verkuyl 1978:90).

The Significance of the Old Testament:

Verkuyl looks at four motifs that he deems to be the indispensable basis for the New Testament call for the Church to be involved in worldwide mission.

1. The Table of nations in Genesis 10.

God who judges the nations according to His goodness and grace observes all peoples revealing that they are all integral to His purpose and plan. Genesis 1-11 records the beginning of humankind and in the Revelation of John reveals Him as the Alpha and Omega, the beginning, and the end. Here “the multitude without number” has been gathered around His throne (Rev.5:9-10, 7:9-17). From Genesis to revelation God reveals that he has plotted that all peoples are part of His scope of salvation and intentions (Verkuyl 1978:91).

2. God’s election of Israel with his eyes on the nations.

Genesis shows a God who seems to “narrow” His interests to a private family and tribe only but as we look at the plan of God unfolding we recognize a separation for a greater purpose that would include all nations (ex.19:3ff; Deut.7:14ff). God’s election was to serve the whole world and whenever they fell away from God He chastised them because they thought they were better than the other nations missing God’s actual intention (Amos 7:9-10) (Verkuyl 1978:91-92).

3. The Breakthrough of the Universal Motif in the exile.

In Israel’s captivity in the seventh and sixth centuries B.C. they came to a realization that their true vocation amongst the nations. When the Prophets prophesied we see a clear intention where God mentioned that His intention was always for the nations

around them to come to salvation through the witness of Israel as a people experiencing Gods ultimate promise (Verkuyl 1978:92).

4. Traces of Universalism in Post-exilic Apocolypticism.

After the exile an “apocalyptical theology” was formed where the coming of the “Son of Man” was predicted who’s Kingdom would put an end to the oppression of the Kingdoms of the World and who will rule all mankind (Dan. 7:1-29). It is conclusive in Old Testament history and prophecy that the whole world is God’s ultimate goal and this reality motivated all God’s actions (Verkuyl 1978:92). Verkuyl mentions three universal ways the Old Testament displays God’s motifs:

The Motif of rescue:

Yahweh is the redeemer of Israel and the Nations. God displays His unique character and His ultimate will for all humankind. The Deutero-Isaiah songs 40-55 shows God’s deliverance will be wrought through His Servant (Isa.49:6) through violent means (Isa.53) (1978:93) to appoint all humanity to experience salvation (Acts 13:47).

The Motif of the missionary:

Verkuyl notes that (1978:94) the election of Israel was never to become a privilege but rather a service that were extended to all (Isa49:6). Israel had a duty to live as a symbol of God’s grace, mercy, and justice becoming a bridge to Yahweh amongst all the nations. Verkuyl does not share other theologian’s views that the Old Testament shows a passive neutral God that seems uninterested in the salvation of all nations but rather affirm that God seems to be keenly interested as well as busy working out the salvation to those who want to believe.

The Motive of Antagonism:

The Old Testament affirms that God is at war with those forces that desire to see His Kingdom defeated and His plan for Universal availability of Salvation thwarted. The Old Testament vision is for liberation of all of creation (Isa.2, Mic.4, and Isa.65) and anticipates God’s ultimate purpose for liberation to be fulfilled. Verkuyl mentions that every nation shall come to know Him as He really is, the “gracious and merciful God,

slow to anger" wanting all humanity to be turned from coming disaster (Jon.4:1-2) (Verkuyl 1978:95-96).

The Book of Jonah:

Verkuyl mentions that Jonah is a *Midrash* revealing a significant biblical basis of missions because it reveals God's mandate for His elect and God's intention of salvation towards the gentiles. This unique book was written with a specific purpose in mind and shows God have a specific will and command revealed in the overall plot. First, the title reveals an unwilling prophet offended by God's initiative to save the gentiles. Second, this book was widely known in the 2nd century and the Jews were aware of their missionary duty to the gentiles and warned against a "perverted view of Israel's election." Third, Verkuyl mentions that it is quite amazing that this "ethnocentric" book that extends salvation to gentiles is at all found within the canon of Scripture as a witness to the New Testament church and also an indictment against Israel. Fourth, the book shows Israel's preoccupation only with themselves without a concern for the salvation of the nations around them. This should remind the New Testament Church of the dangers of the same folly (Verkuyl 1978:97).

The intertestamental period:

Verkuyl mentions that research in the period of the Jewish Diaspora shows a Jewish effort to proselytize Gentiles. He notes that the Jewish message was different from the New Testament Gospel of God's Kingdom and the Christian belief that Jesus was the Messiah. The focus of Palestinian Judaism was to assimilate Gentiles into fellowship where the Jewish community outside Palestine put the emphasis on monotheism. The Jews proclaimed an "auto-soteric" message maintaining specific rituals and elements to attain it. Jesus and Paul both discourage this legalism amongst the Jews and show its deficiency to please a Holy God (Matt.23:15, Rom.2:17-24). Verkuyl highlights the fact that Jesus and Paul was not opposed to Jewish missions to a gentile people but against the "legal support" they deem necessary to legitimise the salvation of God (Verkuyl 1978:101).

The New Testament: Book of World Mission:

Verkuyl affirms that the New Testament is thoroughly missional from beginning to end. He attributes the Earliest Church with the recording of their own missionary tasks as mentioned in the Gospels, the Book of Acts, and the Epistles but most importantly the Person and Work of Jesus Christ (Verkuyl 1978:101-102).

Jesus, Saviour of the world:

Verkuyl mentions, “All the various Old Testament motifs converge in the person and work of Jesus of Nazareth.” The Transfiguration (Mark9:2-13) reveals the global, messianic, and missional motifs epitomized in the person of Christ. The passage reveals more though, in that Jesus is revealed as greater as Moses and Elijah fulfilling the will of God for the entire world. Christ’s very words make the Old Testament “old” and mark the beginning of a new dispensation or Testament. Verkuyl mentions that early on in the book of John the Gentile-Samaritan citizens first mentions that Jesus was indeed the “Saviour of the World” (Joh.4:42) (Verkuyl 1978:102).

The arrival of the All-embracing Kingdom of God:

Jesus highlights in the temple that His very presence is the fulfillment of the coming of the Kingdom that the Prophets of the Old Testament bore witness off (Luke 4:21, Isa.61). His very presence shows that salvation is already come and that it is yet coming awaiting its final fulfilment in the finishing work of Jesus Christ. God’s eternal plan became clear in the deeds and person of the Messiah (Verkuyl 1978:102). The New Testament speaks of the salvation that have appeared for all people and the Kingdom that is to come. Verkuyl mentions that this creates an anticipation and an assurance of that which was needed to be accomplished to bring the world back into fellowship with God.

The manner of the coming Kingdom:

The miracles and parables of Christ points to how this Kingdom was revealed. These miracles addressed human needs but Jesus still anticipated Easter even though His Kingdom works points to this ultimate purpose. Christ shows and says that the apostolic work of the Church globally is the reason for the interim period between His ascension and ultimate return as the Son of Man (Verkuyl 1978:103).

Jesus and the Gentiles:

The Gospels record that Christ interacted and even travelled amongst the gentiles (Joh.4, 12:20-36, Mark 5, Luk8:26-56) and He mentions emphatically that ultimately they will be included in the feast (Isa.25:6-12, Matt.8:11). Verkuyl mentions that it is noticeable that Jesus is “itching with holy impatience” waiting for the message to go out to the gentiles. He restricts Himself for a time until all conditions are met where Israel must hear first (Matt.10) and the rest can receive the final work of salvation (Mark10:45, 14:24).

The Cross & resurrection:

Verkuyl mentions that this is the “foundation for World Missions”. Jesus on the cross endures the punishment for Jew and Gentile and in His resurrection is affirmed that His sacrifice was acceptable to the Father. Now the message of liberation and acceptance could be extended to all peoples through the Cross and resurrection which gives ultimate meaning to the mandate of God’s message. Verkuyl mentions several ways the missionary mandate is mentioned (Verkuyl 1978:104).

The mandate of mission proposed by Verkuyl

The Missionary mandate in the Gospel of Matthew:

Matthew’s Gospel is one of the earliest sources stipulating a Jewish and Christian understanding of the Gospel message of Jesus Christ. In Matthew 10 Jesus instructs His Disciples to proclaim the message to Israel and in Chapter 28 instructs the very Disciples to go to all people and tongues. For Matthew the way to the Gentile mission only opened up after the resurrection. Matthew shows the primacy of Israel

in God's ultimate plan for the Worlds salvation. Chapter 10 and 28 is therefore not a contradiction but complimentary to each other in the full scope of God's plan (Verkuyl 1978:105). All the other Gospels and the book of Acts stipulate the importance of this global mission. Verkuyl mentions that the conclusion of Matthew's Gospel proclaims a three-point message to His Disciples: a) *Jesus Authority* – He mentions His authority to judge and liberate with all authority given to Him and speaks of the same stature as the Son of Man (Dan.7:13-14, Matt.26:64) showing the mission mandate is as a result of His enthronement. b) *Jesus' continuing mandate to mission* – Verkuyl asks (1978:106); "what does the Enthrones Lord command His Disciples to do?". Jesus uses the Greek word "poreuthentes," which means "to depart, to leave, and to cross boundaries." Verkuyl adds; "sociological boundaries, racial boundaries, cultural boundaries, geographic boundaries." He also instructs them to make Disciples of "all nations," "baptising them" implying a change of status in the "name of the Father, Son and Holy Spirit." Verkuyl notes that the Trinitarian baptismal right sets it off from Jewish proselyte baptism and Gnostic purification rites and confer the power of Jesus. Jesus mentions then to "teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you" which shows that the Disciple is covered in Baptism but shown in the teaching of Christ how to live as Christ (Verkuyl 1978:107). c) *Jesus' promise* – Jesus promise His disciples that He will be with them always in a new way. He will be with them by His Holy Spirit. Verkuyl mentions that the exalted Christ's presence within His Church is "the richest gift and her real genius." This mandate to go into the entire world will not end until the end of the world (Verkuyl 1978:108).

The Mission mandate in the Gospel of Mark:

The Author of the Gospel of Mark intends for his book to win gentiles over to Jesus Christ and His Kingdom, which reveals a missional intent. Verkuyl shows through the Gospel author shows a clear parallel between what was taught orally and that which was written down about the death, burial, and resurrection of Jesus Christ, to depict every nation and tongues true need which has always been fulfilled in the Messiah (Verkuyl 1978:109). Verkuyl mentions that verses 15 and 16, even though disputed, shows a clear missionary mandate with its unique charge to baptise and that Matthew's "to all nations" is rendered here as "into all the world". Verkuyl notes that this means that the disciples were to journey the world over seeking to make

converts and that there is no real option that means either “salvation or condemnation” calling them to a new life (Verkuyl 1978:109).

The Mission mandate in the Gospel of Luke and the Acts of the Apostles:

Luke faithfully records the missionary mandate that he has collected from a variety of sources commenting on the life and purpose of Jesus Christ. Verkuyl mentions that Christians were not only called to witness about the resurrection of Jesus but also the promise of the Holy Spirit. Luke clearly describes the scope of the mandate as to the whole world with a specific message proclaiming the events of Jesus Christ (Verkuyl 1978:110). Another interesting point Verkuyl mentions is the specific order that Apostles were to follow as they went into the entire world. They were to start in Jerusalem and then go to Samaria and then the ends of the world. Jesus is also hailed as one reserving the function of knowing the time or the hours to the Father alone. Lastly, Verkuyl mentions that the ascension of Christ and the coming of the Holy Spirit is a parallel event discharging the mandate (Verkuyl 1978:111).

The Mission mandate in the Gospel of John:

Verkuyl mentions that the Author of the Gospel of John had three intentions in writing the Gospel and the Epistles. He wanted to bring people to faith in Jesus (Joh.20:31), show his readers Jesus “came in the flesh” (1Joh.4:2-3) and to continue the fellowship people had in Christ (1Joh.1:3). With that said he adds that the Johannine corpus shows a deep interest in the Disciples call into world missions (Joh.4:35-38, 13:20, and 17:18). Jesus commands them explicitly to go as the Father have mandated Him to go empowered with the Holy Spirit (Joh.21:21-22) (Verkuyl 1978:111).

A critical response: Verkuyl mentions that the ultimate priority in both Old and New Testaments is to show God’s original purpose was to save and liberate the entire world through Israel as a nation. He mentions that God’s heart was always that even gentiles in the Old Testament would come to the covenant realization and his work of salvation. This is what the New Testament looks to show, God’s saving work through history welcoming all nations to have a relationship restored in Him.

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